A Bit-Exact, Processor-Free FPGA Adaptive Noise Canceller: Fair Comparison of LMS, NLMS and Divider-Free NLMS-Shift on Cyclone IV E

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Abstract

Adaptive noise cancellation with a reference microphone is a classical application of the least-mean-square (LMS) family, and a small field-programmable gate array (FPGA) can perform it at audio rates without any processor. This paper presents ULLAP, a 12-bit, 32-tap noise canceller for the DE2-115 board (Cyclone IV E) and its WM8731 codec. One serial core with a single shared multiplier implements LMS, normalized LMS (NLMS) with a restoring divider, and NLMS-Shift, in which a leading-one detector and a shift take the place of the division. With step sizes tuned on held-out seeds, NLMS-Shift matches NLMS within the 95% confidence interval on stationary and amplitude-step noise (22.37 and 24.33 dB over 20 seeds), outperforms LMS by about 2 dB on amplitude steps, and needs 72 rather than 130 busy cycles per sample. NLMS-Shift is also shown to be equivalent to NLMS with a level-dependent step between 0.5 and 1 times the nominal step. On real recorded noise and speech, the filters remove 11.7–14.9 dB and raise short-time objective intelligibility from 0.69–0.78 to 0.95–0.98; without speech they remove 18.5–31.9 dB, so the speech, not the noise, limits performance. A 12-bit word keeps the quantization loss below 0.4 dB on broadband noise. On the board, all 724,459 captured output samples of the three algorithms equal those of the integer model, and the measured sample rate, latency and busy cycles agree with the register-transfer-level design.

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1. Introduction

Few places where people live or work are free of noise. An office air conditioner hums, a compressor runs beside a production line, road noise fills a car cabin, and a hearing-aid user is surrounded by the chatter of other people. If a second microphone can be placed near the noise source, the noise reaching the main microphone can be predicted from this reference signal and subtracted. The predictor is an adaptive filter: it learns the acoustic path between the two microphones while the system runs and follows the path when it changes. For this filter, the least-mean-square (LMS) algorithm and its normalized version (NLMS) remain the usual choice. Both cost only a few multiply–accumulate operations per tap and per sample, and their behavior has been studied for decades [1].

A small embedded device has to run this filter in real time, with a short and fixed delay and on very little energy. A field-programmable gate array (FPGA) suits such a task well. The datapath can be shaped around the algorithm, the latency is known to the clock cycle, and no processor or operating system is needed for scheduling. In hardware, however, LMS and NLMS are not equally easy to build. LMS uses only multipliers and adders, but its convergence speed depends on the input level. NLMS removes this dependence by dividing the step size by the input power, at the price of one division per sample. Dividers are slow and large, so recent designs approximate the division instead, with an approximate Newton–Raphson iteration [2], with canonical-signed-digit reciprocals [3], or with a binary reciprocal built from a leading-one detector and a shifter [4]. The crudest option is to round the input power to a power of two, after which the division is a plain shift. This variant is called NLMS-Shift in the rest of the paper.

Two issues in the published work motivated this study. The first concerns tuning. Competing variants are seldom tuned with equal care, so a reported gain can come from a weak baseline rather than from the algorithm. An early version of the present work made exactly this mistake: NLMS-Shift looked 5.7 dB better than NLMS until NLMS was given a sensible regularization constant, at which point the gap vanished. The second issue is the link between model and silicon. Hardware papers usually report area, clock rate

and power. Such figures show that a design fits on the chip; they do not show that the chip produces the same samples as the model behind the accuracy results.

This paper presents ULLAP, a 12-bit, 32-tap adaptive noise canceller for the low-cost Terasic DE2-115 board (Intel Cyclone IV E) and its WM8731 audio codec, and uses it to address both issues. The main contributions are listed below.

1. **One serial core for three algorithms:** LMS, NLMS (with a restoring divider) and NLMS-Shift run on the same serial core and share one multiplier, so the datapath, word length and filter length are identical for all three. The core sits inside a complete audio system with no processor, closes timing at 50 MHz on Cyclone IV E, and is released together with all scripts and data.
2. **A fair comparison:** The step size and regularizer of every algorithm are chosen on held-out seeds by one common rule, and each result carries a 20-seed 95% confidence interval. Synthetic scenarios, real recorded noise and speech, and a reproducible word-length study are all covered.
3. **A bit-exact verification chain:** The chain runs from a Python integer model through the RTL to the board wrapper (86 regression tests, codec, freeze and reset behavior included). Captures of real codec samples on the board show every output sample of all three algorithms to be identical to the model output.
4. **Two explanations backed by measurement:** The first concerns the shift. NLMS-Shift turns out to be NLMS with a step that moves between 0.5 and 1 times the nominal value as the input level changes. Running NLMS with the average of that step reproduces NLMS-Shift within 0.3 dB on broadband noise; on tonal input, however, the step jumps each time the window power crosses a power of two. The second concerns the real recordings. Once the speech is taken out, the same filters remove 18.5–31.9 dB of the same real noise, which means that the lower noise reduction with speech comes from the speech disturbing the adaptation, not from the noise.

The shift normalizer is not new, and no claim is made to it; Section 2 places it among earlier division-free designs.

The remainder of the paper is organized as follows. Section 2 reviews the problem and related work, and Section 3 outlines the system. The algorithms

and the fixed-point model are described in Section 4 and the hardware in Section 5. Sections 6 and 7 cover verification and the experimental set-up, Section 8 reports the results, and Sections 9 and 10 close the paper with a discussion and conclusions.

2. Literature review

2.1. The problem: noise in daily life

Noise is now recognized as an environmental health risk, not just a nuisance. More than 113 million people in Europe live with transport noise above 55 dB(A), and traffic noise alone is estimated to cost about 1.3 million healthy life-years each year through its effects on the heart and blood vessels [5]. Hahad et al. [6] reviewed the evidence linking long-term noise exposure to mental-health disorders and discussed the biological pathways that may be responsible. Hearing loss is the other half of the picture. The World Health Organization puts the number of people living with some degree of hearing loss at about 1.5 billion and expects it to reach 2.5 billion by 2050 [7]. For these listeners, background noise is the main reason speech stays hard to follow, even with a hearing aid. Reducing noise at the microphone, or close to the ear, is useful beside roads, where urban traffic noise lies mostly below 2 kHz [8]; inside vehicle cabins [9, 10]; in ventilation ducts and air conditioners [11]; and in hearing aids [12, 13, 14]. Most of these devices are small, cheap and run on batteries, so the processing must work in real time at low cost and low energy.

2.2. Applications of adaptive noise control

Yang et al. [8] recorded road traffic noise at five sites in Beijing and built a feedforward LMS prototype that removed close to 30 dB(A) of single- and dual-frequency noise below 2 kHz. For a passenger car, Jiang et al. [9] made the FxLMS step size depend on the reference norm and tuned the two parameters of this rule by particle-swarm optimization. Their system, running on a dSPACE board, reached up to 12 dB below 100 Hz and about 3 dB over 20–400 Hz in road tests, against -0.8 to 0.3 dB for plain FxLMS. Zhu et al. [10] drove the car's own loudspeakers to control the first four engine orders; the average reduction at 52 ear-level microphones was 6.2 dB, and 93% of the listeners in a jury test felt more comfortable with the system on. In hearing aids, Yin and Chen [12] weighted the error of a variable-step adaptive feedback canceller, which on a real device converged 35% faster

than a PEM-IMLMS baseline and 60% faster than PEM-NLMS. Husstedt et al. [13] measured six commercial behind-the-ear devices and found that impulse noise reduction cuts C-weighted peak levels by up to 20 dB, about 9 dB on average. A recent systematic review of speech enhancement for hearing aids [14] concluded that deep networks do best in complex acoustic scenes, while hybrids that keep an adaptive filter strike a better balance between latency and computation on wearable devices.

2.3. Adaptive algorithms

Lu et al. surveyed a decade of active noise control algorithms in two parts, one on linear systems [1] and one on nonlinear systems [15]. In both, LMS-type updates are still the base on which most newer methods are built. One popular idea is to run a fast filter and an accurate filter side by side and combine them. Félix et al. [16] proposed a modified convex combination of FXLMS filters that converged faster and attenuated more than both FXLMS and the earlier convex scheme. Zhu et al. [11] joined an adaptive FxLMS filter and a CNN–GRU network through a convex weight to cancel harmonic noise in a bent air-conditioner pipe. A different difficulty arises when the loudspeaker leaks back into the reference microphone and the loop turns unstable; Li et al. [17] handled this case with a Youla-parameterized feedforward controller and an adaptive IIR update, tested on a duct. Each of these methods cancels better, but each adds operations, a network or a whole extra filter to every sample, which runs against what a small FPGA design needs.

2.4. Hardware realizations

Thannoon and Hashim [18] combined a fast retimed RLS filter with a slow LMS filter on an FPGA to remove power-line interference from ECG records of the MIT-BIH database, and reported 24.2% higher SNR and 50% faster convergence than conventional structures. Jagadeeswari et al. [19] applied cut-set retiming to delayed NLMS filters for audio on a Spartan-6 and shortened the critical path from 29.96 to 13.39 ns. For underwater sonar, Karakaya and Aytar [20] built semi-parallel 16-bit NLMS and variable-step LMS filters on an Artix-7; the SNR rose from 8.85 dB to 29.36 and 28.57 dB, respectively, while using 2.51% and 2.91% of the LUTs. Park and Park [21] took another route, letting a small CNN classify the noise and pick one of several fixed filters, which in simulation gave 2.3 dB more SNR than LMS with 53% less dynamic power. Abdi et al. [22] designed a narrowband

controller around a variable-step LMS notch filter on an FPGA to suppress microphonics in a superconducting accelerator cavity. Other groups worked on the arithmetic. Nagabushanam et al. [23] built a multiplier-less LMS filter from distributed arithmetic with offset-binary coding, and da Rosa et al. [24] replaced the multipliers of an LMS power-line canceller with adders and shifters, saving up to 4.98 times in power and 30.46% in area.

2.5. Removing the division from NLMS

Closest to the present study are the papers that attack the NLMS division itself. Guidotti et al. [2] saved power in an NLMS interference canceller with an approximate Newton–Raphson integer divider, and Coelho et al. [25] reduced the cost of adaptive filtering with sum-of-powers-of-two arithmetic. Yao and Huang [3] approximated the reciprocal of the input power by canonical-signed-digit encoded divisors in a 16-tap NLMS FIR filter. Huang and Yao [4] followed with a binary reciprocal approximation for an NLMS IIR filter. On the same DE2-115 board used here, their design needs 5.07 nJ per sample, compared with 8.33 nJ for a 15-bit SRT divider, and lowers the energy per sample by 39.1%, 6.5%, 14.4% and 5.6% relative to the SRT, Newton–Raphson, CSD and lookup-table methods [4]. They also remark that the older idea of rounding the divisor to a single power of two, so that the division becomes a shift, suffers from a large approximation error. That plain shift is exactly NLMS-Shift. Section 8.4 shows that its error acts only as a level-dependent step factor between 0.5 and 1.

No study was found that compares LMS, a true divider and a shift normalizer on a single core with equal tuning and statistical tests, and only a few test a complete audio system with a codec on a board. ULLAP contributes this equal-effort three-way comparison, a bit-exact chain from model to hardware, and an evaluation on real recordings.

3. System overview

Fig. 1 gives an overview of the system. Noise from the source v reaches the primary microphone through an unknown acoustic path h and mixes there with the wanted signal s, while a reference microphone close to the source picks up v directly. The two microphones feed the left and right LINE IN channels of the WM8731 codec, which digitizes both signals and sends them to the FPGA over an I^2S link. Inside the FPGA, the I^2S receiver hands one pair $(x[n], d[n])$ to the ANC core in every sample period. The core returns

the error $e[n]$, that is, the cleaned signal, and the I^{2}S transmitter passes it back to the codec DAC and LINE OUT. An I^{2}C engine programs the codec once after reset. Two slide switches select bypass and freeze the adaptation, a push button resets the system, and four GPIO test points bring out the sample strobe, the output strobe, the busy flag and the frame clock so that the timing can be measured. The whole design is plain Verilog, with no processor and no vendor IP.

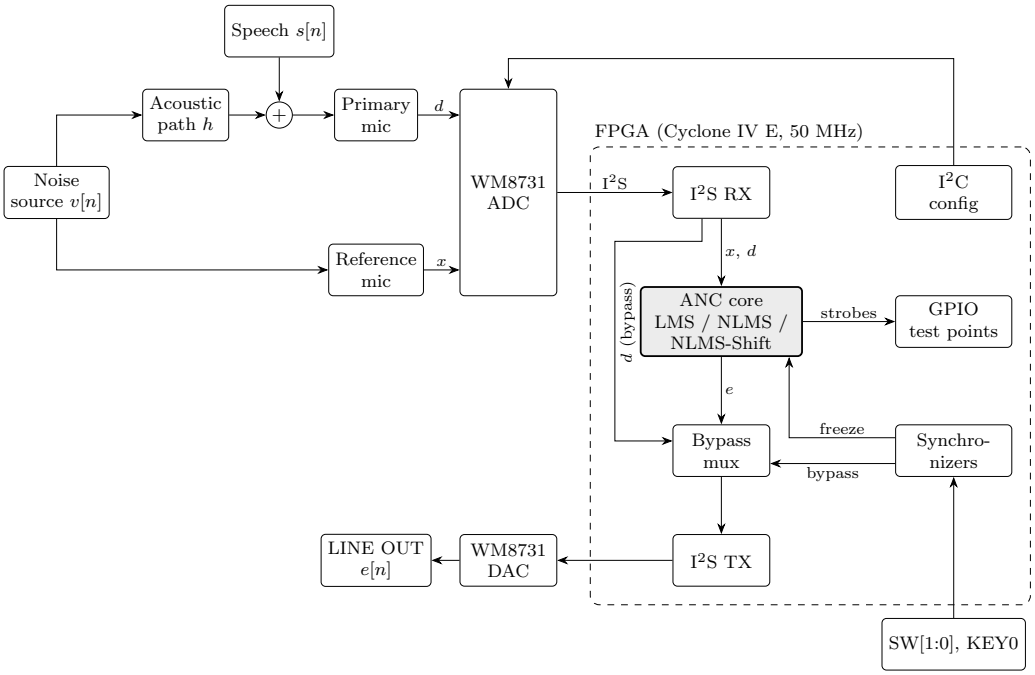


Figure 1: Block diagram of the ULLAP system. In the experiments the acoustic part (upper left) is simulated (Section 7); everything from the codec onwards runs on the DE2-115 board.

4. Algorithms and fixed-point model

4.1. Signal model and cost function

The reference microphone hears only the noise. The primary microphone hears the speech, the noise after the acoustic path, and a little sensor noise

n_s:

$$x[n] = v[n], \tag{1}$$

$$d[n] = s[n] + \sum_{j=0}^{M-1} h_j \, v[n-j] + n_s[n]. \tag{2}$$

With the last L reference samples collected in $\mathbf{x}[n] = [x[n], \ldots, x[n-L+1]]^T$ and the weights in $\mathbf{w}[n] = [w_0[n], \ldots, w_{L-1}[n]]^T$, the filter estimates the noise part of $d[n]$, and whatever remains is the system output:

$$y[n] = \mathbf{w}^T[n] \, \mathbf{x}[n] = \sum_{i=0}^{L-1} w_i[n] \, x[n-i], \tag{3}$$

$$e[n] = d[n] - y[n]. \tag{4}$$

Because s is uncorrelated with v, minimizing the mean-square error

$$J(\mathbf{w}) = E\{e^2[n]\} = E\{d^2[n]\} - 2\,\mathbf{w}^T\mathbf{p} + \mathbf{w}^T\mathbf{R}\,\mathbf{w}, \tag{5}$$

$$\mathbf{R} = E\{\mathbf{x}[n]\,\mathbf{x}^T[n]\}, \qquad \mathbf{p} = E\{d[n]\,\mathbf{x}[n]\}, \tag{6}$$

removes the noise and leaves the speech untouched. Here $\mathbf{R}$ is the autocorrelation matrix of the reference vector and $\mathbf{p}$ the cross-correlation between $d[n]$ and $\mathbf{x}[n]$. The minimum lies at the Wiener solution $\mathbf{w}_o = \mathbf{R}^{-1}\mathbf{p}$, which coincides with the acoustic path when $L \geq M$ and n_s is white.

4.2. LMS, NLMS and NLMS-Shift

LMS replaces the gradient $\nabla J = -2(\mathbf{p} - \mathbf{R}\mathbf{w})$ by its instantaneous estimate $-2e[n]\mathbf{x}[n]$, which leads to the update shared by all three algorithms:

$$\mathbf{w}[n+1] = \mathbf{w}[n] + \mu[n] \, e[n] \, \mathbf{x}[n]. \tag{7}$$

Only the step $\mu[n]$ differs. Writing the window power as $P[n] = \|\mathbf{x}[n]\|^2$, the steps of LMS, NLMS and NLMS-Shift are

$$\mu_{\text{LMS}}[n] = \mu, \qquad 0 < \mu < \frac{2}{L\,\sigma_x^2}, \tag{8}$$

$$\mu_{\text{NLMS}}[n] = \frac{\tilde{\mu}}{P[n] + \epsilon}, \qquad 0 < \tilde{\mu} < 2, \tag{9}$$

$$\mu_{\text{Shift}}[n] = 2^{-(k[n]+K)}, \tag{10}$$

$$k[n] = \lfloor \log_2(P[n] + \epsilon) \rfloor + 1, \tag{11}$$

where σ_x^2 is the reference variance and $\epsilon > 0$ a small regularizer. The LMS bound moves with the input level, which is why a fixed μ ends up too slow for quiet inputs or unstable for loud ones. The NLMS bound stays put. The hardware keeps the power up to date through the exact recursion

$$P[n] = P[n-1] + x^2[n] - x^2[n-L], \tag{12}$$

which costs two squarings per sample instead of L. In NLMS-Shift the exponent $k[n]$ is just the bit length of $P[n]+\epsilon$. A leading-one detector finds it, and multiplying by $\mu[n]$ reduces to an arithmetic right shift of $e[n]\,x[n-i]$ by $k[n]+K$ places.

Proposition 1. *For every n, the NLMS-Shift step* (10) *satisfies*

$$\frac{2^{-K}}{2\,(P[n]+\epsilon)} \;\le\; \mu_{\mathit{Shift}}[n] \;<\; \frac{2^{-K}}{P[n]+\epsilon}, \tag{13}$$

Put differently, the NLMS-Shift step is never more than a factor of two below the NLMS step with $\tilde{\mu} = 2^{-K}$, and it stays inside the NLMS stability bound $0 < \tilde{\mu} < 2$ whenever $K \ge 0$.

Proof. By (11), $2^{k[n]-1} \le P[n]+\epsilon < 2^{k[n]}$. Taking reciprocals and multiplying by 2^{-K} gives (13), since $\mu_{\mathrm{Shift}}[n] = 2^{-K}\,2^{-k[n]}$. □

More precisely, the two steps are related by

$$\mu[n] = \frac{r[n]\,2^{-K}}{P[n]+\epsilon}, \qquad r[n] = \frac{P[n]+\epsilon}{2^{\lfloor \log_2(P[n]+\epsilon)\rfloor+1}} \in [0.5, 1), \tag{14}$$

so NLMS-Shift is simply NLMS with the time-varying step $2^{-K}r[n]$ (Section 8.4). When the input level is unknown over several octaves, the fractional part $u = \log_2(P+\epsilon) - \lfloor \log_2(P+\epsilon)\rfloor$ is spread evenly over $[0,1)$, and the ratio averages to

$$E\{r\} = \int_0^1 2^{u-1}\,du = \frac{1}{2\ln 2} \approx 0.72. \tag{15}$$

4.3. Fixed-point model

Signals and weights are signed $Q1.F$ numbers with $W = 12$ bits and $F = W - 1$ fraction bits. With the rounding shift and the saturation

$$\mathrm{rs}(a, m) = \left\lfloor \frac{a + 2^{m-1}}{2^m} \right\rfloor, \tag{16}$$

$$\mathrm{sat}_B(a) = \min\!\big(\max\!\big(a, -2^{B-1}\big),\, 2^{B-1}-1\big), \tag{17}$$

the integer datapath processes the samples $x_i = x[n-i] \cdot 2^F$ and weights w_i as

$$a[n] = \mathrm{sat}_{B_a}\Big(\sum_{i=0}^{L-1} w_i\, x_i\Big), \tag{18}$$

$$B_a = 2W + \lceil \log_2 L \rceil, \tag{19}$$

$$y[n] = \mathrm{sat}_W\big(\mathrm{rs}(a[n], F)\big), \tag{20}$$

$$e[n] = \mathrm{sat}_W\big(d[n] - y[n]\big), \tag{21}$$

$$w_i \leftarrow \mathrm{sat}_W\big(w_i + \Delta w_i\big), \tag{22}$$

and the weight increments of LMS, NLMS and NLMS-Shift are

$$\Delta w_i^{\mathrm{LMS}} = \mathrm{rs}\big((M_\mu\, e[n])\, x_i,\ F + 10\big), \tag{23}$$

$$\Delta w_i^{\mathrm{NLMS}} = \mathrm{rs}\big(g[n]\, x_i,\ F\big), \tag{24}$$

$$g[n] = \mathrm{sat}_{W+4}\left(\left\lfloor \frac{2N[n] + Q[n]}{2Q[n]} \right\rfloor\right), \tag{25}$$

$$\Delta w_i^{\mathrm{Shift}} = \mathrm{rs}\big(e[n]\, x_i,\ b(Q[n]) - F + K\big), \tag{26}$$

Here $\mu = M_\mu\, 2^{-10}$, $N[n] = M_\mu\, e[n]\, 2^{2F-10}$, $Q[n] = P[n] + 2^{2F-E}$ for $\epsilon = 2^{-E}$, and $b(\cdot)$ is the bit length of a positive integer. Wherever a value is narrowed, it saturates and sets a sticky flag, so no overflow can pass unnoticed. The integer model (`py/fixedpoint.py`, `py/rtl_model.py`) uses exactly these widths and produces the golden vectors.

5. Hardware architecture

5.1. Core

Fig. 2 shows the core datapath (`rtl/anc_core.v`, vendor-neutral Verilog). The core takes one sample pair per `in_valid` strobe and does all of its arithmetic on one multiplier with a three-stage pipeline (operand registers, product register, consume stage). A finite-state machine walks through each sample: two cycles square the new and the dropped reference samples for (12) (NLMS and NLMS-Shift only), L cycles form the filter sum (18), and one cycle produces y and e (21). The step computation comes next, followed by L cycles of weight updates (22). For the gain $g[n]$, NLMS adds a sequential restoring divider; NLMS-Shift has a leading-one detector and a shift-amount register instead. A `freeze` input holds the weights while filtering continues.

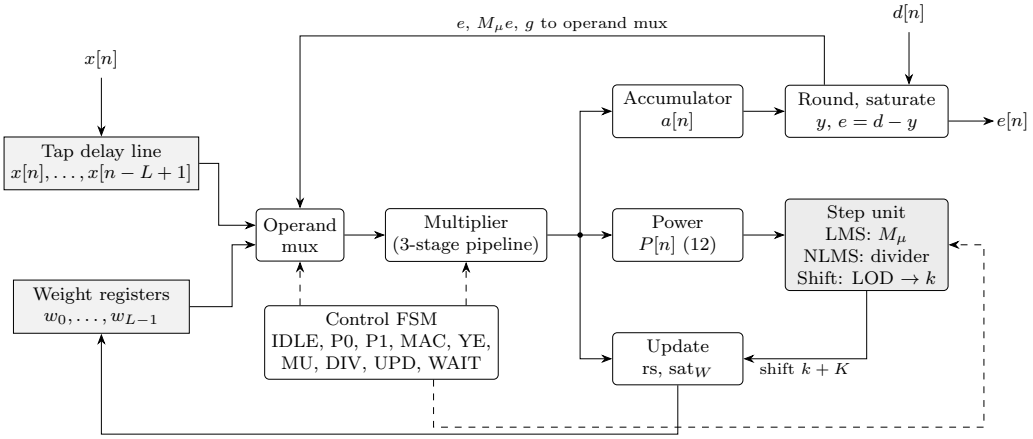


Figure 2: Datapath of the ANC core. The power update, filter sum, step computation and weight updates all share one multiplier; the three algorithms differ only in the step unit. Dashed lines are control signals.

With this schedule, the input-to-output latency and the number of busy cycles per sample are fixed:

$$N_{\text{lat}} = \begin{cases} L + 3 & \text{LMS}, \\ L + 5 & \text{NLMS, NLMS-Shift}, \end{cases} \tag{27}$$

$$N_{\text{busy}} = \begin{cases} 2L + 9 & \text{LMS}, \\ 2L + 13 + N_{\text{div}} & \text{NLMS}, \\ 2L + 8 & \text{NLMS-Shift}, \end{cases} \tag{28}$$

The restoring divider takes one iteration per dividend bit, $N_{\text{div}} = W + B_\mu + 2F + 4 + \lceil \log_2 L \rceil$, with B_μ the signed width of M_μ, so the NLMS cycle count grows with the step-size constant. For $L = 32$ and the tuned settings, the formulas give latencies of 35, 37 and 37 cycles and busy times of 73, 130 ($N_{\text{div}} = 53$) and 72 cycles, exactly the values measured on the board (Section 8.6).

5.2. Board wrapper

Around the core, the DE2-115 wrapper holds an I^{2}C engine that configures the WM8731 at reset (11 registers, every write acknowledge-checked), an I^{2}S receiver and transmitter, two-flop synchronizers on the reset and switches, a frame-latched bypass multiplexer, an overrun flag, and four registered test

points on the GPIO header. The I^{2}S blocks run on the 50 MHz system clock and treat the codec's bit and word clocks as data. The codec is the clock master. It is driven from a 12.5 MHz clock with its sample-rate register at 1536 fs, which sets the sample rate and the number of clock cycles per sample to

$$f_s = \frac{f_{\mathrm{MCLK}}}{1536} = \frac{12.5\ \mathrm{MHz}}{1536} = 8.138\ \mathrm{kHz}, \tag{29}$$

$$N_s = \frac{f_{\mathrm{clk}}}{f_s} = \frac{50\ \mathrm{MHz}}{8.138\ \mathrm{kHz}} = 6144, \tag{30}$$

where f_s is also the rate used in the simulations. The core is busy for the fraction

$$U = \frac{N_{\mathrm{busy}}}{N_s} \tag{31}$$

of every sample period; by (28) that is 1.19%, 2.12% and 1.17% for LMS, NLMS and NLMS-Shift. Again, no processor or vendor IP is involved.

6. Verification

Table 1 summarizes the verification. For 68 configurations (W from 8 to 31, L from 2 to 32, saturation corner cases, freeze patterns), the core testbench compares every $y[n]$ and $e[n]$, the final weights, the sticky flags and the latency with golden vectors. The top-level testbench adds a behavioral WM8731 model that checks each I^{2}C write and follows the programmed sample rate. It runs tests T1–T10: configuration, NACK handling, bypass, end-to-end cancellation against golden vectors, freeze, reset, flags, clocks, a 45-point skew sweep, the 8 kHz rate and the GPIO timing. Faults were also injected on purpose (mutation tests) to make sure the testbenches can actually fail, and every one was caught. Verilator lint with `-Wall` reports no unwaived warning.

7. Experimental set-up

The synthetic scenarios use the reference model $x = v$, $d = s + h * v + n_s$ at 8 kHz with 16,000 samples. There are four of them: stationary colored noise, amplitude steps ($\times 3$ and then $\times 0.25$), an abrupt path switch halfway through, and a recorded chord as the noise source. Step sizes and regularizers were chosen on seeds 101–103 to maximize the mean final noise reduction over

Table 1: Verification summary. All RTL suites pass in both Icarus Verilog and Questa (`results/metrics/iverilog_regression_summary.txt`, `results/local_run_da0b6f4/`).

Suite	Tests	Result
Core golden vectors (`tb_anc_core`)	68	all pass, bit-exact
Protocol corner cases	4	pass
Freeze hold/toggle variants	3	pass
Top level with codec model (T1–T10)	11	pass
Python unit tests	53	pass
Verilator lint (`-Wall`)	–	0 unwaived
On-board Signal Tap captures (T9)	25	all bit-exact
On-board freeze, DAC word, 10-min soak	4	pass

the stationary, amplitude-step and path-switch scenarios, with no overflow allowed. The resulting settings are $\mu = 0.25$ for LMS; $\mu = 0.25$ and $\epsilon = 1$ for NLMS; and $K = 3$ and $\epsilon = 0.25$ for NLMS-Shift. Every reported result uses seeds 1–20. The final noise reduction is measured over the last quarter $\mathcal{N}$ of the samples,

$$\mathrm{NR} = 10 \log_{10} \frac{\sum_{n \in \mathcal{N}} \big(d[n] - s[n]\big)^2}{\sum_{n \in \mathcal{N}} \big(e[n] - s[n]\big)^2} \ \mathrm{dB}, \tag{32}$$

and each table entry is the mean over the $S = 20$ seeds with its 95% confidence interval,

$$\overline{\mathrm{NR}} \pm t_{0.975,\,S-1} \frac{\sigma_{\mathrm{NR}}}{\sqrt{S}}, \qquad t_{0.975,19} = 2.093. \tag{33}$$

Two algorithms A and B are compared through the paired per-seed differences $\Delta_k = \mathrm{NR}_{\mathrm{A},k} - \mathrm{NR}_{\mathrm{B},k}$. They are called equivalent when two one-sided tests (TOST) both reject, at $p < 0.05$, that the mean difference lies outside a margin $\pm\delta$ with $\delta = 0.5$ dB, i.e. when both null hypotheses

$$H_{01}: \ \bar{\Delta} \le -\delta, \qquad H_{02}: \ \bar{\Delta} \ge \delta. \tag{34}$$

are rejected.

Use of generative AI. The authors used Claude (Anthropic) as an assistant during this work: for writing and debugging the analysis scripts and testbench code, for searching and summarizing the literature, and for drafting and editing the manuscript text. [TBD: Authors: add any other AI tools

you used (for example for local runs or literature searches) and adjust the list above if needed.] Every reported number was checked by the authors against the committed result files and board captures, each reference was checked against its source, and the authors take full responsibility for the content of this article.

For the real recordings, four noise files (air conditioner, vacuum cleaner, copy machine, babble) and ten utterances were taken from the public MS-SNSD corpus[1] and resampled to 8 kHz. Each seed draws a noise segment, an utterance and a random 16-tap acoustic path at 0 dB input SNR, once without and once with speech leaking into the reference at -20 dB. Noise reduction, short-time objective intelligibility (STOI) and narrow-band perceptual evaluation of speech quality (PESQ, ITU-T Recommendation P.862) are computed after a 2 s convergence window.

8. Results

8.1. Synthetic scenarios

Table 2: Final noise reduction, dB, mean [95% CI] over seeds 1–20, $W = 12$, $L = 32$ (`results/paper_numbers.csv`).

Scenario	LMS	NLMS	NLMS-Shift
Stationary	22.39 [22.12, 22.66]	22.28 [22.01, 22.54]	22.37 [22.11, 22.63]
Amplitude steps	22.36 [21.72, 23.00]	24.16 [23.58, 24.73]	24.33 [23.88, 24.78]
Path switch	18.95 [18.81, 19.09]	18.53 [18.39, 18.67]	18.91 [18.76, 19.06]
Recorded chord	5.69 [5.66, 5.73]	5.73 [5.69, 5.76]	5.46 [5.42, 5.50]

As Table 2 shows, NLMS-Shift ties with NLMS on stationary noise and amplitude steps, and with LMS on stationary noise and the path switch. On amplitude steps both normalized algorithms beat LMS by about 2 dB. The fixed LMS step is the problem there: it is either too slow after the drop or too noisy before it, and no LMS step size reaches 22 dB on stationary noise and 24 dB on amplitude steps at once, whereas both NLMS variants do (Fig. 3). On the recorded chord NLMS-Shift gives up 0.2–0.3 dB. The paired per-seed tests in Table 3 put a number on "tie". All NLMS-Shift versus NLMS differences fall inside the ± 0.5 dB equivalence margin (TOST,

[1] `https://github.com/microsoft/MS-SNSD`

$p < 0.05$), although some are statistically non-zero, for example +0.38 dB on the path switch. The 1.8–2.0 dB lead of the normalized algorithms over LMS on amplitude steps is significant ($p < 10^{-7}$).

Table 3: Paired differences in final NR over seeds 1–20 (`results/metrics/paired_stats.csv`).

Scenario	Pair	Mean diff. (dB)	95% CI	p (paired t)	TOST ±0.5 dB
Stationary	NLMS-Shift − NLMS	+0.10	[+0.01, +0.18]	0.028	equivalent
Stationary	NLMS-Shift − LMS	-0.02	[-0.07, +0.04]	0.58	equivalent
Stationary	NLMS − LMS	-0.11	[-0.18, -0.04]	0.0038	equivalent
Amplitude steps	NLMS-Shift − NLMS	+0.17	[-0.12, +0.47]	0.23	equivalent
Amplitude steps	NLMS-Shift − LMS	+1.97	[+1.51, +2.43]	2.8e-08	not equiv.
Amplitude steps	NLMS − LMS	+1.79	[+1.38, +2.21]	2.5e-08	not equiv.
Path switch	NLMS-Shift − NLMS	+0.38	[+0.30, +0.47]	1.9e-08	equivalent
Path switch	NLMS-Shift − LMS	-0.04	[-0.07, -0.01]	0.018	equivalent
Path switch	NLMS − LMS	-0.42	[-0.50, -0.34]	1.1e-09	equivalent
Recorded chord	NLMS-Shift − NLMS	-0.27	[-0.30, -0.24]	7.7e-14	equivalent
Recorded chord	NLMS-Shift − LMS	-0.24	[-0.26, -0.22]	2.6e-16	equivalent
Recorded chord	NLMS − LMS	+0.03	[+0.00, +0.06]	0.036	equivalent

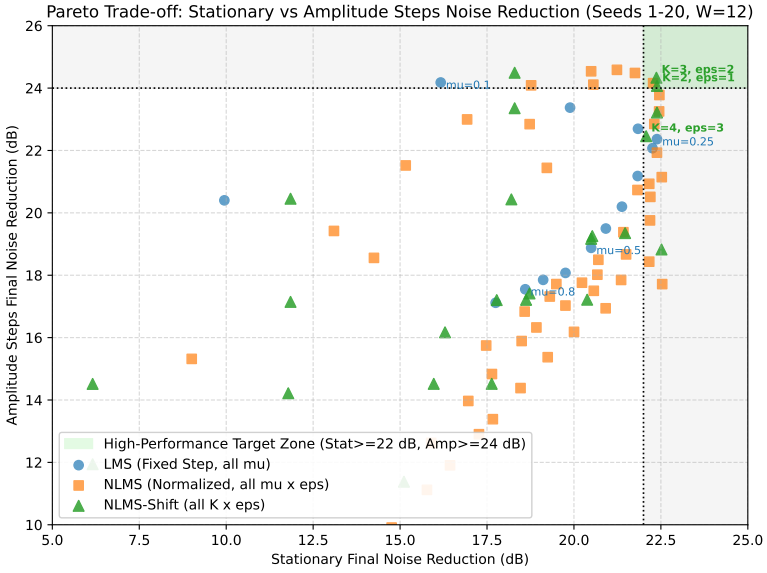


Figure 3: Noise reduction on stationary noise against that on amplitude steps over a range of step sizes (seeds 1–20).

Single runs (seed 1) at the fair-tuned settings appear in Figs. 4–6: the running noise reduction in each scenario (Fig. 4), the residual error power against the input noise power for stationary noise (Fig. 5), and the response

to the amplitude steps (Fig. 6). After the drop at 1.2 s, LMS settles roughly 3 dB below both normalized algorithms, in line with Table 2.

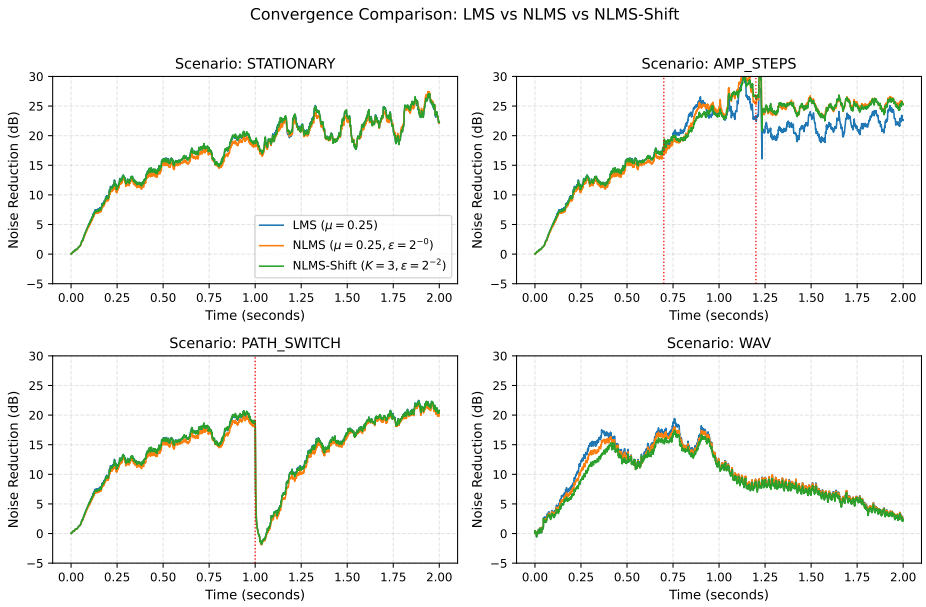


Figure 4: Running noise reduction in the four synthetic scenarios (seed 1, $W = 12$, $L = 32$, fair-tuned settings). Dotted lines mark the amplitude steps and the path switch.

8.2. Real noise and speech

On all four real noises (Table 4) the filter roughly doubles PESQ and pushes STOI close to 1. The ranking of the algorithms never changes: NLMS is 0.4–0.6 dB ahead of LMS, and NLMS-Shift 0.15–0.35 dB behind NLMS. The noise reduction is lower than in Table 2, yet the real noise is not harder to predict. With the speech removed from the primary input, the same filters on the same noise segments and paths reached 18.5–19.2 dB on the air conditioner and 22.4–31.9 dB on the other three noises, as much as on synthetic stationary noise or more (`py/exp_real_audio_nospeech.py`, `results/metrics/real_audio_nospeech.csv`). The speech is uncorrelated with the reference, but it still enters the error $e[n]$ that drives the weight update, and this costs 6.4–17.9 dB. Without speech LMS leads both normalized variants on all four noises; with speech it loses the most (7.6–17.9 dB against 6.4–14.8 dB for NLMS), so the order flips. The usual remedy is to slow

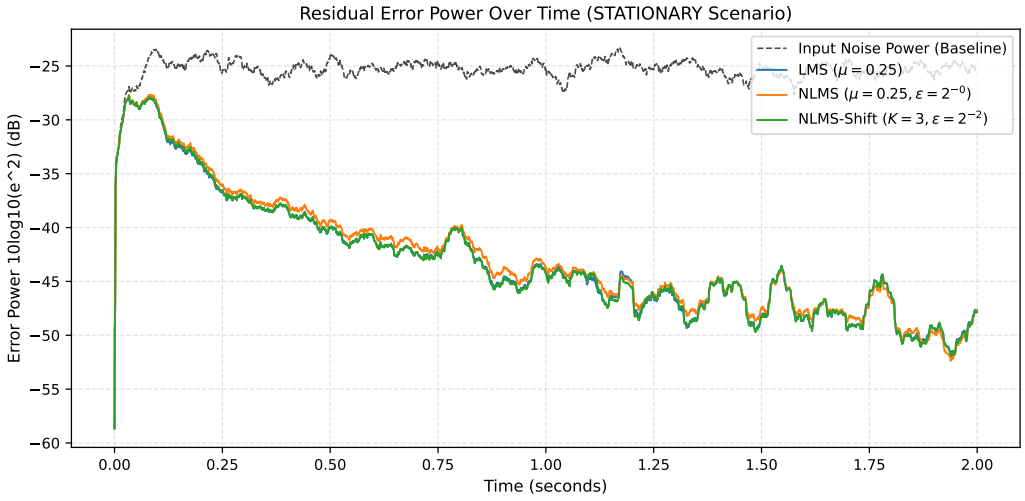


Figure 5: Residual error power over time compared with the input noise power in the stationary scenario (seed 1).

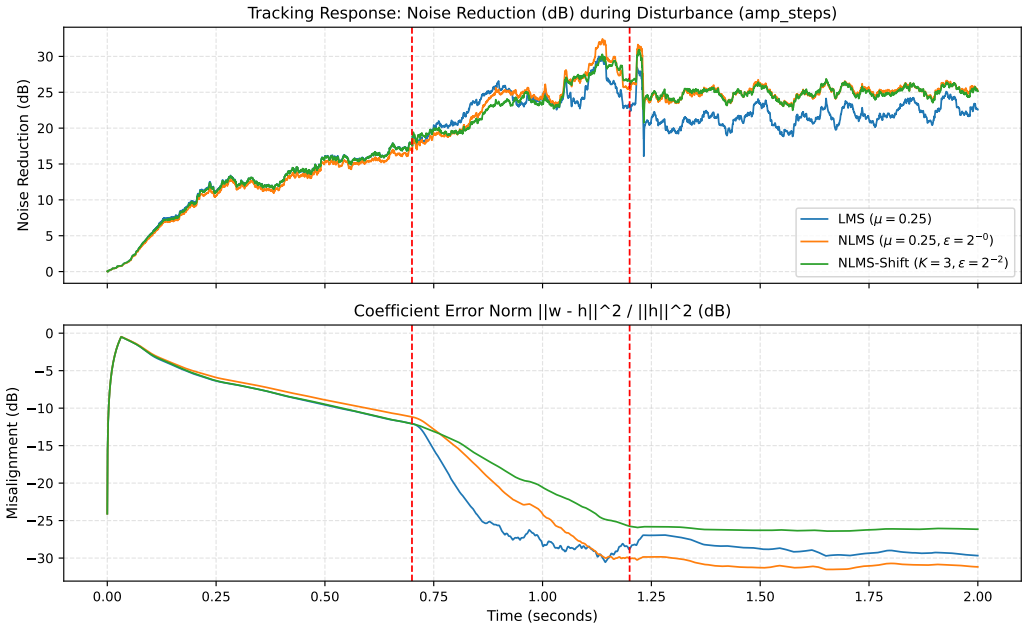


Figure 6: Response to the amplitude-step disturbance (seed 1), shown as noise reduction and coefficient misalignment.

Table 4: Real recorded noise and speech (MS-SNSD), fixed point $W = 12$, mean ± 95% CI over 20 seeds, no speech leakage into the reference; STOI and PESQ of e against s, with the unprocessed input in brackets (`results/metrics/real_audio_summary.csv`).

Noise	Metric	LMS	NLMS	NLMS-Shift
Air conditioner	NR (dB)	11.65 ± 0.75	12.04 ± 0.82	11.89 ± 0.80
	STOI (input 0.784)	0.948	0.947	0.948
	PESQ (input 1.54)	2.34	2.30	2.33
Vacuum cleaner	NR (dB)	14.32 ± 0.32	14.90 ± 0.33	14.56 ± 0.35
	STOI (input 0.730)	0.982	0.983	0.982
	PESQ (input 1.39)	2.81	2.81	2.81
Copy machine	NR (dB)	14.02 ± 0.38	14.63 ± 0.34	14.39 ± 0.32
	STOI (input 0.694)	0.977	0.978	0.977
	PESQ (input 1.36)	2.74	2.75	2.73
Babble	NR (dB)	11.95 ± 0.42	12.43 ± 0.49	12.27 ± 0.46
	STOI (input 0.719)	0.956	0.955	0.955
	PESQ (input 1.48)	2.48	2.47	2.47

down or stop adaptation while someone is talking. The core's `freeze` input (Section 5.1) could be driven by a voice-activity detector for this purpose, although that has not been evaluated here. When −20 dB of the speech leaks into the reference, the filter cancels part of the speech as well: noise reduction falls by 2.3–4.6 dB, PESQ by 0.25–0.6, and saturation events appear (18,500 over 19.2 million processed samples, mostly for the air conditioner). Where the reference microphone sits thus matters more than which algorithm is used (`paper/tab_real_audio_xt.tex`).

8.3. Word length

At the tuned settings, the worst-scenario loss relative to a floating-point run of the same algorithm is 4.1–5.9 dB at $W = 10$, 0.9–1.2 dB at $W = 11$ and 0.3–0.4 dB at $W = 12$ (Fig. 7). Eleven bits is the shortest word that meets the 3 dB criterion; 12 bits were kept for margin. The tonal chord recording behaves oddly. There the fixed-point filter beats floating point by up to 3.4 dB at $W = 11$ but loses 1.3 dB at $W = 13$, because on such a narrow-band signal quantization alters the effective adaptation. The chord result therefore swings with the word length and is not a sound basis for choosing it.

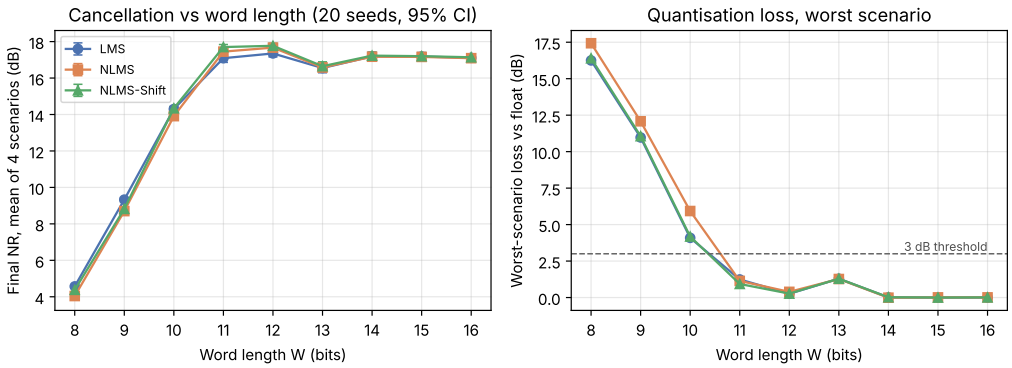


Figure 7: Noise reduction and worst-scenario quantization loss versus word length (20 seeds).

8.4. Equivalent step size of NLMS-Shift

According to (14), NLMS-Shift and NLMS differ only by the factor $r[n]$. Averaged over input levels spread evenly on a logarithmic scale, $E[r] = \int_0^1 2^{u-1}\,du = 1/(2\ln 2) \approx 0.72$. At a fixed level, though, r depends on where $P+\epsilon$ falls inside its octave: it rises with the level and halves as $P+\epsilon$ crosses a power of two. With $L = 32$ and $\epsilon = 2^{-2}$, the crossing $P + \epsilon = 1/2$ lies at a reference RMS of -21.1 dBFS, 3 dB above the simulation level. To observe the effect, the input level was swept over 12 dB in 0.75 dB steps in the integer model (`py/exp_equiv_step.py`), both on the stationary scenario (seeds 1–5) and on a two-tone reference (Fig. 8). With broadband noise the window power fluctuates enough to smooth out the sawtooth, and the mean ratio $\bar{r}$ moves gradually between 0.56 and 0.78. With the tonal reference P is nearly constant, and $\bar{r}$ falls from 0.87 to 0.62 within 0.75 dB of level. In both cases NLMS with the constant step $\bar{r}\,2^{-K}$ reproduces NLMS-Shift: the final noise reduction agrees within 0.27 dB at all 17 broadband levels and within 0.55 dB at every tonal level except the one straddling the crossing (1.7 dB), and the convergence time agrees within 8%. NLMS with the nominal step 2^{-K} misses by up to 3.5 dB and 48%.

The shift, then, alters nothing in the adaptation apart from the step size. It turns the fixed NLMS step into one that lies between 0.5 and 1 times the nominal value, set by the input level. For broadband input this is a smooth gain change, and choosing K (and ϵ) for the expected level absorbs it. For tonal input the step changes by up to a factor of about 0.7 whenever the level

crosses a power-of-two boundary of $P+\epsilon$, something that never happens with fixed-step NLMS.

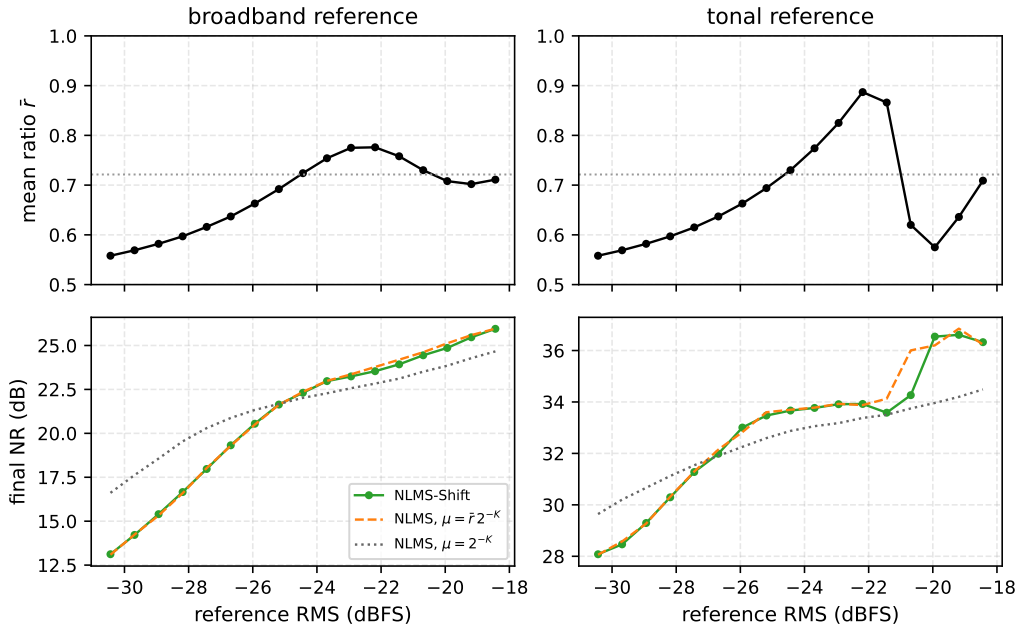


Figure 8: Equivalent step of NLMS-Shift versus reference level (integer model, $W = 12$, $L = 32$, $K = 3$, $\epsilon = 2^{-2}$). Top: mean ratio $\bar{r}$ of (14); dotted: $1/(2\ln 2)$. Bottom: final noise reduction of NLMS-Shift, of NLMS with step $\bar{r}\,2^{-K}$ and of NLMS with step 2^{-K}. Left: stationary scenario, seeds 1–5; right: two-tone reference (`results/metrics/equiv_step.csv`).

8.5. Hardware cost

LMS is about 31% smaller than either normalized variant. NLMS-Shift and NLMS need practically the same logic (2,610 and 2,626 logic elements), because the area saved on the divider is spent on the leading-one detector, the shifter and the wider update path. NLMS-Shift does have 15% fewer registers, needs 45% fewer busy cycles per sample and toggles 16% fewer bits per sample. All three designs meet the 50 MHz constraint with at least +2.953 ns setup slack and +0.401 ns hold slack and raise no critical warnings. At 8.138 kHz even the busiest variant occupies only 2% of the 6,144-cycle sample period, which leaves room for many channels or much longer filters on one core.

Table 5: Complete board design (core, codec interface, synchronizers, status logic) on Cyclone IV E EP4CE115F29C7, $W = 12$, $L = 32$, Quartus Prime Lite 25.1, commit da0b6f4 (`results/quartus_reports/board_da0b6f4/`, `results/metrics/power_activity.csv`).

	LMS	NLMS	NLMS-Shift
Logic elements	1,792	2,626	2,610
Registers	1,123	1,404	1,186
9-bit multipliers	4	4	4
$F_{\max}$, slow 85 °C (MHz)	70.08	59.75	58.66
Setup slack at 50 MHz, slow 85 °C (ns)	5.731	3.263	2.953
Latency (cycles)	35	37	37
Busy cycles per sample (measured on the board)	73	130	72
RTL bit toggles per sample	5,668	7,146	6,012
Core dynamic power, vectorless (mW)	20.79	24.36	23.77

The power figures are vectorless Quartus estimates at the default 12.5% toggle rate, which Quartus itself rates as low confidence. Core static power (about 98.7 mW) dominates the 169 to 173 mW total. The dynamic estimates order the designs LMS < NLMS-Shift < NLMS, the same order as the toggle counts. A fixed toggle rate, however, mostly follows area and ignores that the datapath is idle for 98% of every sample period, so these numbers are upper bounds rather than energy per sample. A gate-level, activity-annotated estimate is left for future work: the post-fit netlist flattens the hierarchy that the top-level testbench observes, and a netlist-only testbench is needed first. A fair comparison with Huang and Yao [4], who used the same board, would report energy per sample as dynamic power divided by sample rate from an activity-annotated Power Analyzer run. That result is not yet available, so no energy comparison with their design is claimed. Their design is also fully parallel and runs at megasamples per second, while ULLAP shares one multiplier and runs at 8.138 kHz; area and energy must therefore be compared per tap and per sample, not as raw totals.

8.6. On-board results

The board evidence comes from Signal Tap on the FPGA itself, so no external recorder or oscilloscope was needed. One logic-analyzer instance stores, once per sample, the two codec samples entering the core (x and d, register outputs `x_reg` and `d_reg`) together with the core output e. It uses a transitional storage qualifier on `out_valid`, triggers on the release of the

reset button and holds 32,768 samples (4.0 s). A second instance samples the four GPIO test points at 50 MHz. The stimuli, the noise-only versions of the four scenarios, were played from a laptop into LINE IN after a 1 kHz calibration tone. Reset was pressed during the tone, so each capture starts from zero weights on real codec data at about −25 dBFS, and no captured sample reaches full scale. The analysis script and raw exports are in the repository (`py/analyze_board_capture.py`, `board_evidence/`).

Bit-exactness. For each of the 12 captures (three algorithms, four scenarios), the integer model of Section 4 was started from zero state at the first sample after reset and fed with the captured x and d. It reproduced every captured $e[n]$ without a single mismatch: 351,723 samples in total, 28,672 to 32,768 (3.5 to 4.0 s) per capture. The fixed-point arithmetic on the chip is thus exactly the arithmetic evaluated in simulation, even with analog input carrying the codec's noise and offsets.

Timing. In the GPIO capture, the `in_valid` period is 6,144 clock cycles (8,138.02 Hz), the spacing from `in_valid` to `out_valid` is 38, 36 and 38 cycles for NLMS-Shift, LMS and NLMS (core latency plus one accept cycle, or 0.76, 0.72 and 0.76 μs), and the busy times are 72, 73 and 130 cycles. Each value equals the RTL simulation with the same parameters. The builds containing Signal Tap still meet the 50 MHz constraint (setup slack +2.65, +5.68 and +3.78 ns); Table 5 refers to the builds without the logic analyzer.

Fig. 10 compares the three algorithms on the same amplitude-step stimulus, aligned to the start of the scenario. (KEY0 was pressed by hand during the calibration tone, so the reset lands at a slightly different point of the stimulus in each capture.) All three settle to about 15 dB within the first 1.5 s. At 2.1 s the level of d rises by 7.4 dB, and the filters follow the step with only a short burst in e. The residual power after the step (−47 to −52 dBFS) is below that before it (−44 dBFS), so the noise reduction climbs to 25 to 30 dB. Over the last quarter of the window the reduction is about 40 dB below 1.5 kHz and 11 to 15 dB near the band edge (3.5 to 3.9 kHz).

Noise reduction on the simulation signal. In a second session, the 2 s seed-1 noise-only signal of each scenario (exactly the 16,000-sample signal of the simulations) was played once after the calibration tone, so the whole scenario fits in the capture. Its start was found by correlating the captured x with the stimulus (correlation 0.95 to 0.99), and $\mathrm{NR}_{\mathrm{final}}$ was taken over the same last 25 % as in simulation. All 12 captures (28,672 samples after reset each) are again bit-exact. Table 6 sets the board against the integer model on the same signal. The board falls 2.9 to 10.6 dB short of the simulation,

by similar amounts for all three algorithms, and the reason is the input level rather than the hardware. The codec delivered x and d at about -27 dBFS, 3 dB below the simulation level, and at the tuned step sizes a lower input power slows adaptation within the 2 s. Run at the level the board actually received, the model matches the board within 0.2 dB on stationary and path-switch noise (Fig. 9). The amplitude-step and recorded-noise scenarios end with a quiet final quarter (d at about -41 and -57 dBFS), and there the board remains 1.7 to 8.1 dB below the level-matched model. At such levels two analog effects are no longer negligible next to d: the noise of the playback and codec path (-70 dBFS, measured in the silence after the stimulus) and an ADC offset that decays during the first second after reset. For amplitude steps, even the best 32-tap least-squares filter fitted to the board samples of that window reaches only 24 dB, against 28 dB on the ideal signal. On the board, the three algorithms stay within 0.7 dB of one another in every scenario.

Table 6: On-board $\mathrm{NR}_{\mathrm{final}}$ (dB) on the 2 s seed-1 stimulus against the integer model on the same signal, at the simulation level and scaled to the level the board received (`results/board/session2/`). Every board capture is bit-exact.

Algorithm	Scenario	Board	Model, sim. level	Model, board level
LMS	stationary	15.88	22.77	15.76
	amplitude steps	17.13	27.71	25.23
	path switch	14.67	19.84	14.47
	recorded noise	5.99	9.11	7.78
NLMS	stationary	15.65	21.60	15.53
	amplitude steps	16.76	27.19	23.64
	path switch	14.03	19.06	14.04
	recorded noise	5.80	8.72	7.45
NLMS-Shift	stationary	15.80	22.68	15.78
	amplitude steps	16.57	25.79	22.10
	path switch	14.40	19.86	14.44
	recorded noise	5.46	8.63	7.32

Freeze, DAC word and endurance. With NLMS-Shift running on stationary noise, SW[1] was flipped by hand 1.44 s into the scenario. The captured output equals the model with adaptation stopped from that sample on (28,672 samples, no mismatch). From the switch to the end of the scenario

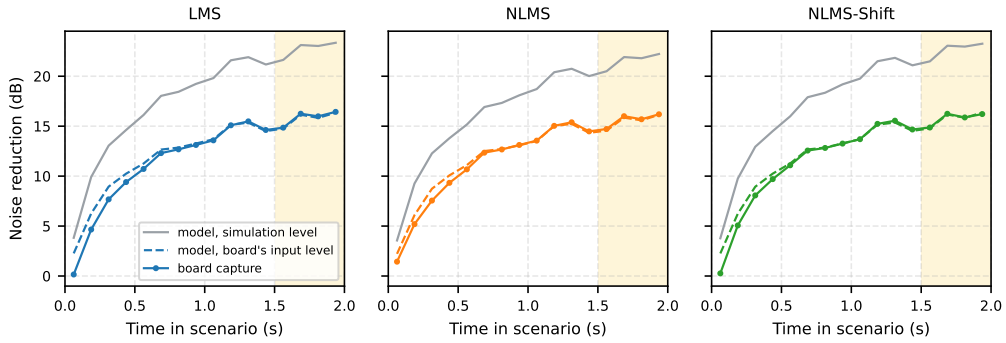


Figure 9: Running noise reduction (0.125 s windows) on the 2 s stationary stimulus: board capture, integer model at the simulation level, and integer model with the stimulus scaled to the level the board received. Shaded: the $\mathrm{NR}_{\mathrm{final}}$ window.

the noise reduction holds at 15.2 dB, compared with 15.4 dB just before the switch and 15.9 dB had adaptation continued. A third Signal Tap instance recorded the word sent to the DAC. In ANC mode it equals $\{e, 0000\}$; in bypass (SW[0] = 1) its upper 12 bits equal d, in all 1,792 samples of each capture. The LINE OUT signal could not be recorded with the equipment at hand, so this check follows the chain as far as the DAC interface. After 10 minutes of continuous operation on looped noise, the GPIO timing was unchanged (6,144 cycles per sample, 38 cycles from `in_valid` to `out_valid`, 72 busy cycles) and no saturation, NACK or overrun flag had been set. The build with all three logic-analyzer instances still met timing (slack +2.93 ns).

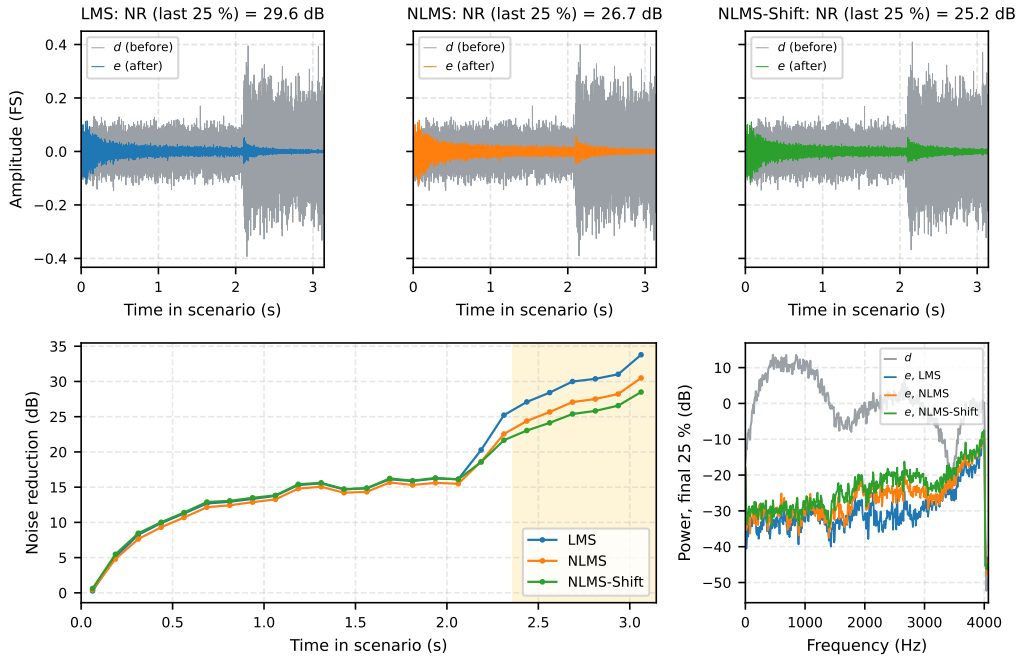


Figure 10: On-board Signal Tap captures of LMS, NLMS and NLMS-Shift on the same amplitude-step noise, from the start of the scenario: primary input d and output e (top), running noise reduction in 0.125 s windows (bottom left; shaded: last 25 % of the common window) and power spectra over that window (bottom right). Every output sample of all three captures equals the integer model's.

9. Discussion and limitations

The comparison supports a fairly narrow conclusion. Divider-free normalization keeps the level independence of NLMS at roughly the cycle count of LMS. It is therefore the better choice when the noise level varies and throughput or energy per sample matters, while LMS remains the smallest design for a steady level. The results do not show that NLMS-Shift cancels better than NLMS, and Section 8.4 explains why: the shift changes only the step size, by a level-dependent factor between 0.5 and 1, so tuning K and ϵ for the expected input level matters more than the shift itself. Tonal noise near a power-of-two boundary of $P+\epsilon$ also sees a step jump that NLMS does not have. On real recordings, the speech at the primary input limits all three algorithms far more than the choice of algorithm does (6.4–17.9 dB, against at most 0.6 dB between algorithms).

Several limitations remain. The acoustic paths are simulated, including those used with the real recordings. Acoustic feedback (closed-loop howling) is outside the scope, and reference-based ANC would not be the right structure for it anyway. Power is represented by a switching-activity proxy until a gate-level analysis is done. On the board, the output is shown to match the model up to the DAC word, but the analog LINE OUT signal was not recorded. Finally, the absolute noise reduction depends on the input level. With the stimulus 3 dB below the simulation level, the board reached 14 to 17 dB rather than 19 to 28 dB on the synthetic scenarios, and on stationary and path-switch noise the model reproduces this at that level. In a deployment, the codec input gain should be set so that the reference uses most of the 12-bit range, or the step size should be retuned for the expected level.

10. Conclusion

This paper presented ULLAP, which runs LMS, NLMS and NLMS-Shift on one serial 12-bit, 32-tap core on a low-cost Cyclone IV board and compares them with equal tuning effort. NLMS-Shift matches NLMS within the 95% confidence interval on stationary and amplitude-step noise while needing 72 instead of 130 busy cycles per sample. All three algorithms remove 11.7 to 14.9 dB of real recorded noise, and 18.5 to 31.9 dB once the speech is removed from the primary input, showing that the speech and not the noise sets the limit. NLMS-Shift was further shown to be equivalent to NLMS with a level-dependent step between 0.5 and 1 times the nominal one. On the board, 25 Signal Tap captures of real codec data (724,459 samples) are bit-exact with the integer model, as are the freeze behavior and the DAC word, and on stationary and path-switch noise the measured noise reduction equals that of the model, at the input level the board received, within 0.2 dB.

Declarations

Funding. [TBD: Authors: funding sources, or "No funding was received for this work."]
Competing interests. [TBD: Authors: competing interests, or "The authors declare no competing interests."]
Author contributions. [TBD: Authors: who did what (free text or CRediT).]

Data and code availability. All RTL, testbenches, scripts and result files are available in the project repository [TBD: public URL and Zenodo DOI of the tagged release]. The real-audio study downloads its MS-SNSD files from a pinned commit and verifies them by SHA-256.
Use of generative AI. Described in the experimental set-up (Section 7).

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